

UNIT 79



FAILURE

CONVERSATION

Sarah: Alright, let's be real for a second. This project went off the rails toward the end.

Mark: Yeah. The last few weeks were a mess. We rushed decisions and cut corners just to stay on schedule.

Emily: And the thing is, some issues showed up early on, but we didn't really slow down to look into them closely. A few warning signs were clearly overlooked.

Sarah: I agree. The writing was on the wall after we missed that first deadline.

Mark: True. If we had acted sooner, we wouldn't have missed the boat with the client.

Emily: Communication didn't help either. We definitely dropped the ball on updates.

Sarah: And instead of dealing with the issues head-on, we swept a few things under the rug.

Mark: Yeah... If we'd handled those issues earlier, we wouldn't be dealing with this now.

Emily: That's right. Anyway... I guess we learned the hard way.



VOCABULARY



Overlook the
warning signs



Cut corners



The writing is on
the wall



Go off the rails



Drop the ball



Miss the boat



Sweep under the
rug



Learn the hard
way

Conditionals: third and mixed

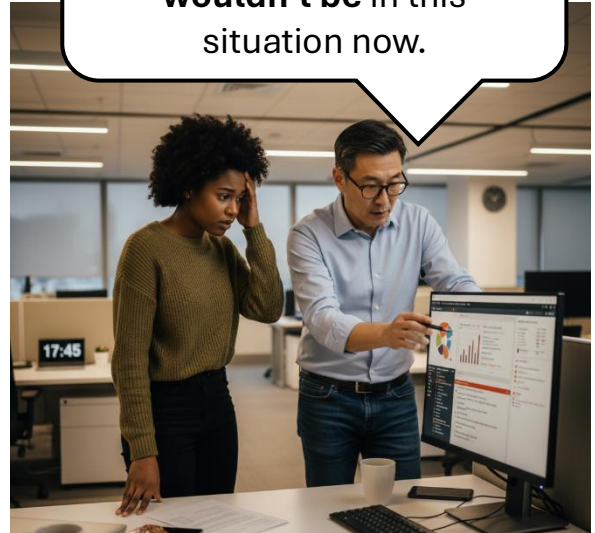
Past – Past (Third)

If we **had acted** sooner, we **wouldn't have missed** the boat with the client.



Past - Present (Mixed)

If we **hadn't overlooked** the warning signs, we **wouldn't be** in this situation now.





FAILURE

EXERCISE 1

Complete the sentences using each expression only once: miss the boat · drop the ball · go off the rails · sweep something under the rug · learn the hard way · cut corners · the writing was on the wall · overlook the warning signs

- A. If we had reacted earlier, we wouldn't have missed the boat with the client.
- B. The project didn't fail overnight. It slowly _____ after the first missed deadline.
- C. We _____ on communication, and the team didn't know what was expected.
- D. Instead of fixing the problem, management chose to _____ until it became impossible to ignore.
- E. We rushed the work and _____ during testing, which affected quality.
- F. Looking back, _____. The signs were there from the beginning.
- G. The team ignored early feedback and completely _____.
- H. The failure was painful, but at least we _____ and won't repeat the same mistakes.

EXERCISE 2

Complete each sentence using the third conditional.

- A. If we had acted earlier, we wouldn't have missed the boat with the client. (act)
- B. The project wouldn't have gone off the rails if we _____ the risks seriously. (take)
- C. If the team _____ corners during testing, quality wouldn't have suffered. (cut)
- D. We _____ in this situation now if management _____ the warning signs. (not be) (not overlook)
- E. If we _____ the problem instead of sweeping it under the rug, it _____ so bad now. (address) (not be)

SUMMARY

Situation	Time Reference	Structure	Example
We imagine a different past and a different result	Past → Past	If + had + past participle, would have + past participle	If we had acted sooner, we wouldn't have missed the boat.
We imagine a different past and how it would affect the present moment.	Past → Present	If + had + past participle, would + verb (base form)	If we had handled it earlier, we wouldn't be dealing with this now.

EXERCISES ANSWER KEYS

Exercise 1

- A. missed the boat
- B. went off the rails
- C. dropped the ball
- D. sweep something under the rug
- E. cut corners
- F. the writing was on the wall
- G. overlooked the warning signs
- H. learned the hard way

Exercise 2

- A. had acted
- B. had taken
- C. hadn't cut
- D. wouldn't be / hadn't overlooked
- E. had addressed / wouldn't be